TRAVEL GUIDE

Country Overview

An introduction for first-time visitors: geography, climate, entry requirements, currency and everything else you need to know before you go.

Prepared for NotebookLM practice exercise - Unicorn University AI Software Development Course

Geography and location

The Dominican Republic occupies the eastern two-thirds of the island of Hispaniola in the Caribbean, sharing a long land border with Haiti to the west. It is the second-largest country in the Caribbean by area (about 48,671 km2) and by population (roughly 11 million). The Atlantic Ocean lies to the north; the Caribbean Sea to the south.

The country is remarkably varied for its size. Along its coasts you find over 1,600 km of beaches, mangroves, and coral reefs. Inland, four mountain ranges dominate the terrain. The Cordillera Central houses **Pico Duarte** (3,098 m) - the highest peak in the Caribbean. Fertile valleys such as the **Cibao** produce cocoa, tobacco, and coffee. The southwest is desert-like, with salt flats, cactus, and the lowest point in the Caribbean at **Lago Enriquillo** (44 m below sea level).

Climate and best time to visit

The Dominican Republic has a tropical climate. Coastal temperatures average 25-31 deg C year-round; mountain temperatures can drop to 10 deg C at night in winter.

- **December to April** - the "high season." Warm, dry, low humidity. This is when most European and North American travelers visit. Prices peak between mid-December and early January.
- **May to July** - "shoulder season." Warm with short afternoon showers. Good value; lush, green landscape.
- **August to October** - "green season" and peak hurricane risk (especially September). Storms are unpredictable; travel insurance is strongly recommended.
- **November** - dry season begins; prices still moderate.

Whale-watching in Samana runs mid-January to mid-March. **Kitesurfing** in Cabarete is at its best from June to August.

Language, currency, and time zone

- **Language:** Spanish. In tourist areas, English is widely spoken by hotel and excursion staff; some German, French, and Italian is heard in Puerto Plata and Sosua.
- **Currency:** Dominican Peso (DOP). Approximate rate ~58 DOP per US$1 (fluctuates). US Dollars are accepted at hotels, resorts, and most tourist businesses, though usually at a worse rate than paying in local pesos.
- **Time zone:** Atlantic Standard Time (AST, UTC-4). No daylight saving.

Entry requirements

- **Passport** must be valid for the duration of the stay. Some airlines require six months of validity.
- **Tourist card** - a US$10 fee is now included in the price of most airline tickets. Independent travelers arriving by other means may still need to pay it at the airport.
- **Stay duration:** Standard tourist entry allows up to 30 days. Overstays incur a departure fee.
- **e-Ticket:** Travelers must complete the free online **Migracion e-Ticket** form within 72 hours of arrival and of departure. It replaces the old paper immigration and customs forms.
- Citizens of the EU, UK, USA, and Canada do not need a visa for standard tourism.

Getting there - main international airports

- **Punta Cana (PUJ)** - busiest, closest to eastern resorts.
- **Santo Domingo - Las Americas (SDQ)** - capital; best for city and southern trips.
- **Puerto Plata - Gregorio Luperon (POP)** - north coast.
- **Samana - El Catey (AZS)** - Samana Peninsula, limited flights.
- **Santiago (STI)** - Cibao Valley, mostly regional and US flights.
- **La Romana (LRM)** - small, mostly charter, serves the Casa de Campo resort.

Safety at a glance

Tourist zones (Bavaro, Puerto Plata, Samana, Bayahibe, Casa de Campo) are heavily policed and generally very safe. In Santo Domingo, stick to Zona Colonial, Piantini, and Naco after dark. Petty theft (bag-snatching, hotel-room theft) is the most common issue. Use hotel safes, keep valuables out of sight, and take licensed taxis or ride-hail apps rather than street cabs.

Money and tipping (quick view)

ATMs are widely available in cities and resort towns. Notify your bank of travel. A **10% service charge (propina legal)** and an **18% ITBIS tax** appear on most restaurant bills; an extra 5-10% cash tip is customary for good service. Tip hotel housekeeping US$1-2 per day.

Key facts snapshot

- **Capital:** Santo Domingo (population ~3.5 million metro).
- **Founded:** Santo Domingo, 1496 - the oldest continuously inhabited European settlement in the Americas.
- **Independence:** 27 February 1844, from Haiti.
- **Government:** Presidential republic.
- **Religion:** Predominantly Roman Catholic, with a growing Evangelical Protestant presence.
- **National sport:** Baseball.
- **National dance:** Merengue (UNESCO Intangible Heritage since 2016). Bachata (UNESCO 2019).
- **National dish:** La Bandera Dominicana (rice, beans, meat, salad, plantains).
- **Voltage:** 110 V / 60 Hz, US-style plugs (Type A/B).